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Léa

September 1943

A bitter cold air seeped through the cement walls in the sick bay's office. Leaves had already begun to scatter on the ground; winter felt around the corner. Josef sat beside Léa with his glasses perched on the crown of his head, pinching the ridge of his nose with his thumb and forefinger.

"What did you just say?" he said, distracted.

Léa had urged him to change his bloodstained clothes—the red had deepened to a wine color. Earlier, he'd spent the afternoon trying to save an Italian worker whose hand had been caught in a milling machine, severing an artery. Josef couldn't stem the bleeding in time. The man died. Later, he'd lamented to Léa about the lack of medical equipment that prevented him from doing his job.

"Should I send Rose with the death certificate to bring with the other reports to the Gestapo office?"

"Yes." He tilted his head to one side. "Why is your sister doing this?"

As if summoned, Rose pushed the office door open. She'd been so quiet that neither Léa nor Josef had heard her open the sick bay's front door. Josef stood.

Rose stared at his clothes, wide-eyed. "What happened?"

"Factory accident," Josef said, sliding his chair to Rose so she could sit. "Léa has told me so much about you. It's an honor to meet you."

"She has told me about you, too. *Énchanté*."

He closed the door, looking uncomfortable, and fixed his eyes on her sister. "Rose. Forgive the lack of preamble. But if I may be frank, I worry about your plan to go to the Gestapo office tonight." He cleared his throat.